Week 5 – Data analysis
Definite Descriptions in Akan

October 21, 2026

1 Background on definiteness

Akan is a tonal language[1] that belongs to the Kwa sub-family of the Niger-Congo family. It is spoken mainly in the southern part of Ghana and part of Ivory Coast. In Ghana, approximately 44% of the population speaks Akan as a native language. This group comprises around 8 million people, according to Osam (2004). In this session, we will focus on Akan definite descriptions, like *the orange* in English, and see how they might differ from those used in more familiar languages, including English and German.

Consider first the following two English sentences:

(1) a. I saw **a** magnolia tree.
b. # I saw **the** magnolia tree

What are the differences between *a* and *the* in English, when uttered out of the blue?

Next, let's look how the meaning of *the* interacts with negation, modals, questions in English:

(2) a. I did**n't** see the magnolia tree.
b. I **may** have seen the magnolia tree.
c. **Did** you see the magnolia tree**?**

What should we conclude about the assertion/presuppositions of *the* in English? Write a tentative λ-entry for *the*.

Now consider the following pair:

(3) Context: it's well-known there is only one sun.

a. # **A** sun is shining.
b. **The** sun is shining.

What does this contrast tell us about the interactions between meaning and context?

Consider these two sentences chained together:

(4) I saw **a** magnolia tree and I saw a cherry tree. **The** magnolia tree looked magnificent.

Does this example lead to you to update your previous semantic defnition of *the*?

Let's make a distinction between two close concepts pertaining to the prerequisites of definite DPs like *the sun* or *the magnolia tree* (also called definite descriptions). They might require their referrent (an individual) to be:

[1] A tonal language uses pitch to distinguish words' meanings or to serve a grammatical purpose. Akan has high and low tones, maked as ´ and ` respectively.

- **uniquely identifiable**, which means the addressee can identify the speaker's intended referent on the basis on which nominal is used, as it refers to a single individual in context. That individual may or may not be already familiar to the hearer.
- **familiar**, which means the addressee already has a representation of the referent in (long- or short-term) memory. Familiar referrents are often uniquely identifiable.

Which concept do (1) and (3) instantiate? Which concept does (4) instantiate?

Let's now have a brief look at German. Schwarz (2009) argued German as weak and strong determiners. Both look the same on the surface, except that weak determiners can be merged with prepositions (e.g. *zum* is a contraction of *zu dem* and means literally 'to the'). At the semantic level, weak and strong determiners are also shown to differ. For instance, they contrast is the following sentences.

(5) Armstrong flog als erster zu**m** / #zu **dem** Mond
Armstrong flew as first one to-**the**$_{\text{weak}}$ / to the$_{\text{strong}}$ moon
'Armstrong was the first one to fly to the moon.'

(6) In der New Yorker Bibliothek gibt es **ein** Buch über Topinambur. Neulich war ich dort und
in the New York library exists EXPL **a** book about topinambur recently was I there and
habe #i**m** / in **dem** Buch nach einer Antwort auf die Frage gesucht, ob man
have #in-**the**$_{\textbf{weak}}$ / in **the**$_{\textbf{strong}}$ book for an answer to the question searched whether one
Topinambur grillen kann.
topinambur grill can
'In the New York public library, there is a book about topinambur. Recently, I was there and looked in the book for an answer to the question of whether one can grill topinambur.'

Describe the difference between strong and weak determiners in German in terms of being familiar vs. uniquely identifiable.

We will now look at Akan definite descriptions to see if their semantics aligns with that of English or possibly German (weak/strong) definite descriptions.

2 The Akan DP

Look at these two Akan sentences, making use of different determiners.

(7) a. Kwámì hwí-ì [àbʊ̀frá (tùntúm) bí]$_{\text{DP}}$
Kwame cane-PAST child black A
'Kwame caned a certain (dark) child.'

b. Context: here suppose it's clear who the child refers to.
Kwámì hwí-ì [àbʊ̀frá (tùntúm) nʊ́]$_{\text{DP}}$
Kwame cane-PAST child black THE
'Kwame caned the (dark) child.'

Based on the odering of the noun, adjective, and determiner in these sentences, draw a tree representing Akan DPs. Give a preliminary semantic characterization of *bí* and *nʊ́*, based on what was observed in English (and potentially German).

Now consider the "chained" sentences below. The emptyset (∅) symbol stands for a null determiner.

(8) Mʊ̀-t-ɔ́-ɔ̀ èkùtú ***n**ʊ́**/bi/**∅. Èkùtú **n**ʊ́**/*bi/***∅ yɛ̀ dɛ̀w pápá
1SG.SUBJ-buy-PAST orange ***THE/A/**∅ orange **THE/*A/***∅ be nice good
I bought an orange. The orange was really tasty.

Describe the uses of determiners in both sentences. Which previous English and German sentences is this sentence most similar to? What does the pattern of determiners suggest about the meaning of nʊ? The realization of strong and weak definites in Akan?

Consider the following contrast:

(9) a. Kòfí hú-ù ɔ̀tʊ̀mfʊ́ **n**ʊ́.
Kofi see-PAST blacksmith **THE**
'Kofi saw the (assumed familiar) blacksmith.'

b. Kòfí hú-ù ɔ̀tʊ̀mfʊ́.
Kofi see-PAST blacksmith
'Kofi saw some blacksmith.'

Are those in line with the data in (8)? Why or why not?

Look at these two naturalistic conversations between a speaker S and an addressee A:

(10) Context: Consultant S has just come home from university.

a. S: Àbʊ̀frá **n**ʊ́ bá-à há.
child **THE** come-PAST here
'The child came here.'

b. A: (with a confused face)
íbɛ̀n àbʊ̀frá à? À-n-ká àbʊ̀frá bíárá hò ásɛ́m ò.
which child Q PAST-NEG-say child every self case EXPL
'Which child? You did not say anything about any child oh!'

(11) Context: out of the blue.

a. S: Èdzìbán **n**ʊ́ yɛ̀ dɛ̀w.
food **THE** be nice
'The food is nice.'

b. A: (looking around for evidence)
Áh é-dzídzí à? íbɛ̀n èdzìbán à?
EXPL PFV-eat Q which food Q
'Ah, have you eaten? Which food?'

Comment on these interactions. Is the reaction of A expected, given your hypothesis about the meaning of nʊ?

Lastly, consider:

(12) Ámstrɔ̀ŋ nyí nyímpá áà ó-dzí-ì kán tú-ù kɔ́-ɔ̀ ɔ̀sìrán dʊ̀
Armstrong is person REL 3.SG.SUBJ-eat-PAST first fly-PAST go-PAST moon TOP
'Armstrong was the first person to fly to the moon.'

Describe the use of determiners in this sentence. Which previous German sentence is it analog to? What does it tell us about strong and weak definites in Akan? Is it consistent ith your previous conclusion? Which slight variant of (12) should we test to flesh out our conclusion even more?

3 Akan vs. German

Let's now compare Akan nʊ to German strong and weak determiners in more details, using a variety of tests.

3.1 Bridging

Bridging is a form of indirect anaphora in which a definite description refers to an entity that has not itself been explicitly introduced into the discourse, but whose identity can be inferred from something that has been introduced. There are two main types of bridging:

(13) a. Part-whole bridging:
Jo entered a house. **The** roof was leaking.

b. Relational bridging:
Jo bought a book. **The** author is French.

In German, part-whole bridging is done with weak definites, while relational bridging is done with strong definites. Given what you learned about strong and weak definites from (5) and (6), sketch why having weak definites in part-whole bridging and strong definites in relational bridging makes sense.

Let's come back to Akan. Consider the two sentences below talking about a sheep and its neck.

(14) a. # Ìgùán nʊ́ sʊ̀ árá mà nyímpá ànán nà wó-dzí-ì kɔ́n nʊ́
sheep THE big just COMP person four and 3.PL.SUBJ-eat-PAST neck THE
'The sheep was so big that it was four people that ate the (sheep's) neck.'

b. Ìgùán nʊ́ sʊ̀ árá mà nyímpá ànán nà wó-dzí-ì ní kɔ́n
sheep THE big just COMP person four and 3.PL.SUBJ-eat-PAST POSS neck THE
'The sheep was so big that it was four people that ate its neck.'

Are these sentences examples of part-whole or relational bridging? What does (14a) tell us? What's the role of (14b)?

Now consider the following two sentences "bridging" a lead drummer to a dance (15a) and a cutlass and a tree (15b):

(15) a. Àsáw nʊ́ yɛ́-è ɔ̀hín nʊ́ fɛ̀w árá mà ɔ̀-kyɛ́-è àyìrbɔ́fʊ́ pényín **n**ʊ́ àdzí
dance THE do-PAST chief THE beautiful just COMP 3.SG.SUBJ-give-PAST drummer lead **THE** thing
'The dance was so beautiful that the chief gave the lead drummer (of the dance) a gift.'

b. Kwámì yɛ́-è dɛ́ɛ̀ ó-rú-twà dùá nʊ́, àdár **n**ʊ́ è-n-túm è-n-twá
Kwame do-PAST COMP 3.SG.SUBJ-PROG-cut tree THE cutlass **THE** PFV-NEG-power PFV-NEG-cut
'Kwame tried cutting the tree but the cutlass (used on that particular tree) could not cut it.'

Are these sentences examples of part-whole or relational bridging? What do these sentences suggest about nʊ? Is that consistent with previous observations?

3.2 Double descriptions

Consider the following German sentence, in which the same individual is described using two nominals:

(16) Maria hat einen Ornithologen ins Seminar eingeladen. Ich halte #vo**m** / von **dem** Mann nicht sehr viel.
Maria has an ornithologist to-the seminar invited. I hold #of-**the**$_{\textbf{weak}}$ / of **the**$_{\textbf{strong}}$ man not very much
'Maria has invited an ornithologist to the seminar. I dont think very highly of the man.'

Given what you know about strong vs. weak definites, explain the pattern of definites in that sentence.

Now consider Akan:

(17) Ámá tʊ́-ʊ̀ ǹsá fré-ɛ̀ ǹnʊ̀màhwɛ̀fʊ́ bí bá-à ǹkyìrɛ̀kyírɛ́ náásí.
Ama throw-Past hand call-Past birds.observer A come-Past teaching.Nom Poss.under
Mì-n-gyí pàpá **n**ʊ́ ǹ-dzí kìtsìkìtsì
1.Sg.Subj-Neg-take man **The** Neg-eat small.Red
'Ama invited a (certain) ornithologist to the seminar. I dont trust the man in the least.'

Is that piece of data consistent with previous observations about nʊ in Akan?

3.3 Singling out referrents

Consider the following sentence in which one of the multiple rooms gets referred to.

(18) Dán kʊ́r nà mé-nyí gyí-ì hʊ́ páá wɔ̀ fíkɛ̀sí ǹsràhwɛ́ nʊ́ áà yɛ́-kɔ́-ì
room one Foc 1.Sg.1.Sg-eye take-Past self more at mansion tour The REL 1.Pl.Subj-go-Past
nʊ́. Mì-tsí-ì dɛ́ɛ̀ Kwámì Ǹkrúmá tsìná-à dán **n**ʊ́ mù wɔ̀ 1923.
The 1.Sg.Subj-hear-Past Comp Kwame Nkrumah sit-Past room **The** in at 1923
'I liked one of the rooms more at the mansion tour we went on. I heard Kwame Nkrumah stayed in the room in 1923.'

Which previously given German example is this sentence analog to, and does the presence of nʊ make sense?

Now consider these German and Akan sentences involving multiple ministers:[2]

(19) Wenn ein Minister den anderen Ministern im Kabinett den Haushalt kürzt, dann gehen
when a minister the other ministers in-the$_{weak}$ cabinet the budget cuts then go
#bei**m** / bei **dem** Minister viele Beschwerden ein.
by-**the$_{weak}$** / by **the$_{strong}$** minister many complaints in
'When a minister cuts the budget of other ministers in the cabinet, the minister receives a lot of complaints.'

(20) Sɛ̀ ɔ̀sʊ̀ányì tsìw sìká áà ɔ́-kɔ̀ àsʊ̀áfʊ́ à-fʊ́fʊ́r hɔ́n sìkàsɛ́m hʊ́ ǹtʊ̀tʊ̀í mʊ̀ dʊ̀ á
if minister plug money Rel 3.Sg.Subj-go ministers Pl-new 3.Pl.Poss budget in on Part
wɔ̀-kánfʊ̀ ɔ̀sʊ̀ányí **n**ʊ́ yéè.
3.Pl.Subj-praise minister **The** well
'If a minister cut the budget of other ministers, the minister is well praised.'

Are they consistent with each other in their use of definites? Make sense of the choices of definites in both cases.

4 Wrinkles(?)

Consider the same sentence about cassava in a basket, uttered in two different contexts.

(21) a. ?? Context: speaker is coming back from the market with their usual basket but addressee has no clue what they bought.
Ésì fá bànkyí **n**ʊ́ áà ɔ́-gú kɛ̀ntsɛ́n mù nʊ́ bɪ̀rà
Esi take cassava **The** Rel it-pour basket in The come
Intended: 'Esi, bring the cassava that is in the basket.'

b. Context: speaker and addressee have discussed how the cassava in the basket should be used before the cassava on the shelf for cooking.
Ésì fá bànkyí **n**ʊ́ áà ɔ́-gú kɛ̀ntsɛ́n mù nʊ́ bɪ̀rà
Esi take cassava **The** Rel it-pour basket in The come

[2]This is an elaboration of so-called "bishop sentences", of the form *When a bishop meets a bishop, he blesses him*, in which the pronouns can seamlessly "find" their antecedents despit them being introduced by the same indefinite phrase.

'Esi, bring the cassava that is in the basket.'

Compare these sentences to English equivalents in the same context. Do you notice anything unexpected? Specifically comment on what seems to be going on in (21a).

Now, consider the following Akan sentence in which specific sets of mangos are made familiar.

(22) Mángʊ̀ ànán gù kòtòkú nʊ́ mú, Ámá hú-ù èbáàsá, mángʊ̀ / kʊ́r nʊ́ áà wáyíw
mango four pour sack THE in Ama see-PAST three mango / one THE REL 3.SG.SUBJ.PFV.miss
nʊ́ nà ɔ́-yè-dɛ́w páá
THE FOC 3.SG-SUBJ-do-nice more
'There are four mangoes in the sack, Ama found three. The missing mango/one is nicer.'

Would you expect the missing mango to be referred to using nʊ**? Why or why not?**

Let's look at a related example: a sentence in which the indefinite *a guest book* is in the so-called "nuclear-scope" of the quantifier *every*.

(23) Dán bíárá wɔ̀ àhɔ̀hʊ̀ búùkùú dà mú, hɛ́n dán mù hɔ́ búùkùú **n**ʊ́ m̀fònyí
room every at guest book sleep in 3.PL.Poss room in there book **THE** picture
á-fɛ́ɛ̀fɛ́w wɔ̀ mú.
PL-beautiful at in
'Every room has a guest book, in our room the book there has beautiful pictures in it.'

Would you expect the book in the room to be referred to using nʊ**? Why or why not?**

Laslty, consider this German-Akan pair.

(24) Context: You and your spouse own one dog. While your spouse is away, someone breaks into your house and you are telling them about it on the phone. You say:
   a. Der Einbrecher ist zum Glück vo**m** / #von **dem** Hund verjagt worden
   the burglar is luckily by-**the**$_{\textbf{weak}}$ / #by **the**$_{\textbf{strong}}$ dog chased been
   'Luckily, the burglar was chased away by the dog.'
   b. Òwìfʊ́ nʊ́, bɔ̀dɔ́m **n**ʊ́ ká-à nʊ́-dʊ́ árá má ɔ̀-gúán-ìì
   thief THE dog **THE** follow-PAST 3.SG-OBJ-on just so 3.SG-SUBJ-run-PAST
   'The thief, the dog chased away.

Are the German and Akan sentences consistent with each other in their use of definites? For each pattern, discuss whether it would have been expected in context.

References

[Gundel et al., 1993] Gundel, J., Hedberg, N., and Zacharski, R. (1993). Cognitive status and the form of referring expressions in discourse. *Language*, 69:274–307.

[Osam, 2004] Osam, E. K. (2004). *An Introduction to the Structure of Akan: Its Verbal and Multiverbal System*. University of Ghana-Legon.

[Schwarz, 2009] Schwarz, F. (2009). *Two Types of Definites in Natural Language*. PhD thesis, University of Massachusetts Amherst.